Ashima Suvarna

Los Angeles, California - 90024

asuvarna31@cs.ucla.edu
https://asuvarna31.github.io/

Research Interests

My research focuses on data curation, evaluation, and post-training methods that enable language models to reason robustly across open-ended tasks. I am interested in safety, reasoning, multi-agent systems and coding agents.

Education

University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA) — Sept 2024 - Present
Ph.D. in Computer Science — *Advisor - Prof. Saadia Gabriel*

University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA) — Sept 2021 - Sept 2023
Masters in Science - Computer Science; Deepmind Scholar — *Advisor - Prof. Nanyun Peng*

Delhi Technological University (Formerly DCE) — Aug 2016 - June 2020
Bachelor of Technology - Computer Engineering

Selected Publications

1. **Ashima Suvarna**, Kendrick Phan, Mehrab Beikzadeh, Hritik Bansal, Saadia Gabriel.
SuperNova: Eliciting General Reasoning in LLMs via Reinforcement Learning on Natural Instructions [Paper]
EMNLP Findings 2026

2. Akhila Yerukola, Fabrice Y Harel-Canada, Simran Khanuja, Abhinav Sukumar Rao, **Ashima Suvarna**, Nanyun Peng, Saadia Gabriel, Maarten Sap.
NormViz: A Benchmark and Framework for Grounding Multimodal Reasoning in Global Cultures
COLM 2026

3. **Ashima Suvarna**, Christina Chance, Karolina Naranjo, Hamid Palangi, Sophie Hao, Thomas Hartvigsen, Saadia Gabriel. *ModelCitizens: Representing Community Voices in Online Safety.* [Paper]
EMNLP 2025

4. Hritik Bansal*, **Ashima Suvarna***, Gantavya Bhatt*, Nanyun Peng, Kai-Wei Chang, Aditya Grover.
Comparing Bad Apples to Good Oranges: Aligning Large Language Models via Joint Preference Optimization. [Website]|[Paper]| [Code]
ACL Findings 2025

5. Etash Guha, Ryan Marten, Sederick Keh, ... **Ashima Suvarna**,... Alexandros G. Dimakis, Ludwig Schmidt.
OpenThoughts: Data Recipes for Reasoning Models. [Paper]|[Code]
ICLR 2026 (Oral)

6. Salman Rahman, Sheriff Issaka, **Ashima Suvarna**, ... Yejin Choi, Julian Michael, Liwei Jiang, Saadia Gabriel. *AI Debate Aids Assessment of Controversial Claims.* [Paper] **NeurIPS 2025**

7. **Ashima Suvarna***, Xiao Liu*, Tanmay Parekh, Kai-Wei Chang, Nanyun Peng.
QUDSELECT: Selective Decoding for Questions Under Discussion Parsing. [Paper]|[Code]
EMNLP 2024

8. Zefan Cai*, Po-Nien Kung*, **Ashima Suvarna**, ..., Nanyun Peng.
Improving Event Definition Following For Zero-Shot Event Detection. [Paper]
ACL 2024

Preprints

1. **Ashima Suvarna**, Ruta Desai, Ahmed Ghoneim.
Blind Spots: Where small terminal agents fall behind frontier models **RAAI@NeurIPS 2026**

2. **Ashima Suvarna**, Harshita Khandelwal, Nanyun Peng.
PhonologyBench: Evaluating Phonological Skills of Large Language Models. **KnowledgeableLMs@ACL 2024**

Community-Led Projects

OpenThoughts-Agent Project Blog
*An open-source effort to curate the best datasets for training agents. Released **OpenThinker-Agent-v1** the best model of its size on Terminal-Bench 2.0.*

OpenThoughts Project Blog
*An open-source effort to curate the best open reasoning datasets. Released **OpenThinker3-7B**, a SOTA open-reasoning model trained using only supervised fine-tuning.*

Evalchemy: A framework for gold standard language model evaluations Github
A unified and easy-to-use toolkit for evaluating post-trained language models on math and coding benchmarks. Developed as part of DataComp community and built on LM-Eval-Harness.

Work Experience

Microsoft AI Redmond, Washington
Research Scientist Intern (Host: Ahmed Ghoneim & Ruta Desai) *Jun 2026 - Sept 2026*

PLUSLAB, UCLA Los Angeles, California
Research Associate (Advisor: Prof. Nanyun Peng) *Jun 2023 - July 2024*

Walmart Inc. Sunnyvale, California
Data Scientist Intern (Host: Zongjun Tan & Utkarsh Porwal) *Jun 2022 - Sep 2022*

Dimagi Inc. New Delhi, India
Technical Project Analyst *June 2020 - August 2021*

University of New Brunswick Fredericton, Canada
Mitacs Research Intern (Advisor: Prof. Paul Cook) *June 2019 - August 2019*

Awards and Scholarships

- **UCLA Graduate Fellowship** to support graduate research; awarded to selected students in Fall 2024.
- **Deepmind Scholarship** to fully fund Masters at UCLA CS; awarded to 2 MS students in Fall 2021.
- **Mitacs Globalink Research Scholarship** to conduct research and visit Canada for Summer 2019.
- General Secretary of **Enactus DTU** in 2018; won the **KPMG Grant** to rehabilitate acid-attack survivors.

Community Initiatives

- Organized the **UCLA NLP Seminar Series** [Website] where premier AI/ML researchers present cutting-edge research via talks, 1:1 research discussions and social meetups.
- Created **SheFrames** [Website] a crowd-sourced art project to celebrate women in STEM through comic-style illustrations of submitted stories and anecdotes.
- Member of **GWiCS**, community building at UCLA CS with events like LoFi and Study Hours.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to NLP (UCLA CS 162) *Spring 2025*
Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Robotics (UCLA CS 188) *Winter 2026*

Service

Reviewer: ACL SRW 2024, NAACL SRW 2024, ICLR Tiny Papers 2024, NeurIPS D&B 2024, EMNLP 2025, COLM 2024, COLM 2025, COLM 2026
Program Committee: SoCal NLP Symposium 2023
Volunteer: Enactus DTU 2016-2018, Mentorship Office-Hours